Draft for discussion

Marlow Crossing: independent review of forecast cost and opening date

Independent cost and schedule review for the Marlow Crossing Authority Board

Marlow Crossing Authority | 10 November 2026 | Independent Review Team

Confidential and proprietary. For internal discussion only.

The review puts final cost at £337m and opening in June 2028; the project says £312m and January 2028

£312m ●

Project forecast cost (EAC)

Project cost report, September 2026

£337m ●

Review view of cost

£25m (8.0%) above the project

28 Jan 2028 ●

Project opening date

Project schedule, September 2026

23 Jun 2028 ●

Review view of opening

21 weeks later than the project

1. Scope: the Marlow Crossing cable-stayed bridge and approaches. Method: 27 interviews, a re-run of the project schedule and a line-by-line check of the cost report. Documents are dated to 30 September 2026. The review team had no role in design or delivery. RAG: green means the review agrees with the project; red means the review differs by more than 5% on cost or 8 weeks on date.

Source: Independent review team analysis of project documents as of 30 September 2026. Fictional example.

The project's forecast is optimistic on productivity, utilities and steel, and we expect a later opening

Cost

- We add **£29m** of risks the forecast leaves out, and remove £4m counted twice
- Review view is **£337m**, 8.0% above the project

Schedule

- Pile caps are running 12 weeks behind and delay everything after them
- Review view of opening is 23 June 2028, 21 weeks later

Findings

- Six findings: two high, three medium, one low
- Both high findings are on the critical path

What we ask

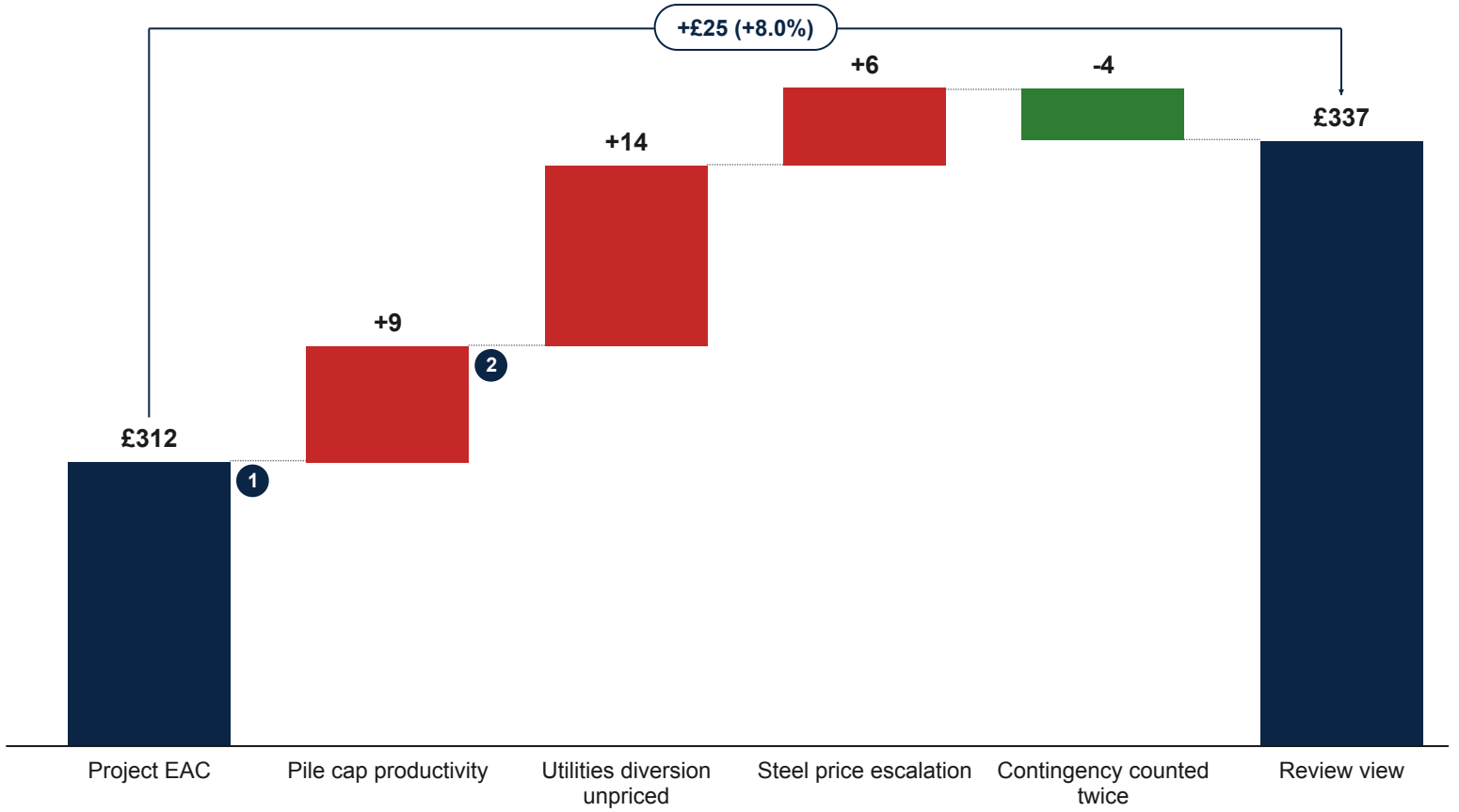
- Reforecast to the review view, then fund contingency at P80
- Fix the two high findings before the next payment milestone

Source: Independent review team analysis of project documents as of 30 September 2026. Fictional example.

The review adds £25m to the project's £312m forecast, mainly for pile cap productivity and unpriced utilities

Project forecast cost to review view of cost

£m, nominal, September 2026, project estimate class 3



Where we disagree

1. Pile caps take 14 weeks per cap, not the 10 weeks in the forecast: **+£9m**.
2. The utility owner's diversion quote of **£14m** is not in the forecast.
3. Contingency is held in two budget lines, so we remove **£4m**.

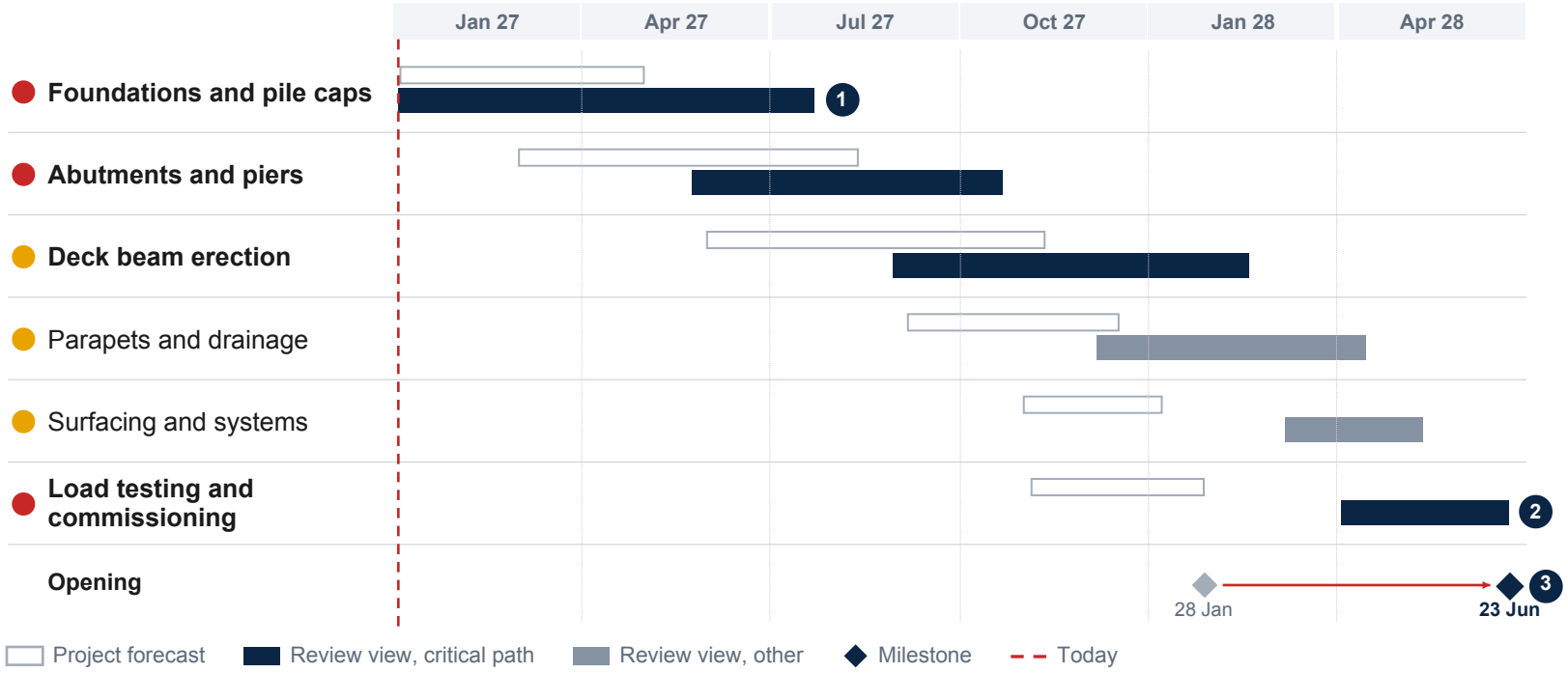
1. Increases are shown in red. Utilities diversion excludes any claims from the utility owner.
2. Vertical axis starts at £290m.

Source: Independent review team analysis of project documents as of 30 September 2026. Fictional example.

The review expects opening 21 weeks after the project's date because pile caps delay the whole chain

Project forecast against review forecast

Level 2 schedule, January 2027 to June 2028



What the schedule shows

1. Pile caps finish 12 weeks late, and nothing downstream has float to absorb it.
2. Testing takes about 12 weeks in both plans, and neither has any float.
3. Opening moves from 28 January to 23 June 2028.

1. The review view re-runs the project's schedule logic with measured productivity.

Source: Independent review team analysis of project documents as of 30 September 2026. Fictional example.

Six findings, two of them high severity, explain the gap between the project and the review

Review findings by severity

Evidence as of 30 September 2026

#	Finding	Severity	Effect	Evidence	Owner
1	**Pile cap productivity is below the forecast rate**	High	+£9m, +12 weeks	Site records, caps 1 to 6	Construction director
2	**Utility diversion quote of £14m is not in the forecast**	High	+£14m	Utility owner quote, 14 Aug	Commercial director
3	**Steel escalation uses a stale index**	Medium	+£6m	Mill order dates, index	Commercial director
4	**Testing window has no float**	Medium	Up to 6 weeks	Schedule logic check	Planning manager
5	**Contingency held in two budget lines**	Medium	-£4m	Cost report lines 41 and 58	Finance lead
6	**Risk register not updated since June**	Low	None directly	Register version history	Risk manager

Low Medium High severity

1. Severity: Red = high (changes cost by more than £5m or opening by more than 8 weeks); Amber = medium (£1m to £5m or 2 to 8 weeks); Green = low (below those).

Source: Independent review team analysis of project documents as of 30 September 2026. Fictional example.

The Board should reforecast to the review view and fund the two high findings before the next payment milestone

#	Decision required	Recommendation and impact	Owner	By
1	**Reforecast cost to £337m and opening to 23 June 2028**	Adopt the review view as the planning basis until the project can evidence its own faster rates	Project director	15 Dec
2	**Agree the £14m utility diversion with the utility owner**	Negotiate a fixed price before the October 2027 diversion window closes	Commercial director	31 Jan
3	**Commission a pile cap productivity recovery plan**	Contractor to present a plan with a second rig option and its cost	Construction director	29 Jan
4	**Re-run the quantified risk analysis on the new forecast**	Set contingency at P80 and publish the confidence level	Risk manager	28 Feb

Source: Independent review team analysis of project documents as of 30 September 2026. Fictional example.